

TIRBHUWAN TIWARI



(FROM LEFT) ADVANI, VAJPAYEE AND FORMER RSS CHIEF K.S. SUDARSHAN

the Centre may have won it brownie points in TV debates but no electoral gain. In fact, it was during this period that the party lost its traditional middle class and urban support. For proof, look no further than the fact that in the 2004 general elections, the BJP lost 42 of the 56 urban constituencies it had won five years earlier. The tally fell further this year. Amidst the gloom at the national level, the states offer a glimmer of hope: of the 17 assembly elections held in the north and central Indian states since the party was voted out at the Centre in 2004, the BJP and its NDA coalition partners have won nine, while the Congress and its allies won only seven.

With the party at its most vulnerable, corrective measures were long overdue. The RSS stepped in quietly at the state level. First to face its ire was Uttarakhand where the party had failed to retain a single seat in the 15th Lok Sabha. So B.C. Khanduri stepped down and Ramesh Pokhriyal Nishank took over as the fifth chief minister. In Rajasthan, not only was the state unit chief replaced; the RSS also went after former chief minister Vasundhara Raje, who, in any case, was never

among the favourites. Raje tried to mount a counter-offensive but was forced to back off after two of her supporters were summarily shown the door.

By year-end, party elections are due. Rajnath may get to stay on with the blessings of the RSS but there will be no shortage of aspirants. Modi, Sushma, Jaitley, Apte, former president M. Venkaiah Naidu may all have an eye on the post and the results of these will determine whether the party will get back to its roots or will continue on its journey to embrace modernity. Bhagwat, as the youngest-ever sarsang-chalak at 59, has hinted at the need for a generational change at the top which may well see the end of the Advani era. If he goes, so will a host of others who basked in his reflected glory. But elsewhere, leaders who walked the beaten RSS track, quietly and without flamboyance will have the full backing of the parent organisation. Shivraj, Raman, B.S. Yeddyurappa, P.K. Dhumal, Modi, all chief ministers, and the likes of Sushma will have a meaningful role in turning the party's fortunes around in the years to come. Their commitment to the party is supplemented by their ability to distinguish the dividing line between dissent and discipline. And a strong BJP serves the RSS' interests well since it affords it protection against onslaught from ideological opponents.

By expelling Jaswant from the party, the RSS was clearly targeting more than the man himself. It wanted to send a strong message to the rest of the party—leaders and cadre alike—against deviating from party ideology and rebellion. The churning may have just begun. In the short run, it will be painful. But getting back to basics, it seems, may be the only way forward for the saffronites.

with inputs by Malini Bhupta, Shyamal Yadav and Uday Mahurkar

POOR COORDINATION WITH ALLIES AND BAD MEDIA MANAGEMENT ARE BEING CITED AS SOME OF THE MAIN REASONS FOR THE BJP'S DISMAL SHOW